

Encourage her to find safe ways to provide goods or services to the community. That could mean walking dogs, mowing lawns or pet-sitting for friends or family who are out of town. She could offer to clean an elderly neighbor's garage or pull weeds in a neglected garden. I've known kids who make their own jewelry or decorate candles, then turn around and sell their creations for a profit. I call them little E.T.s—Entrepreneurs in Training.

A friend of mine has a daughter who was an E.T.: she launched her first business at age 11. Her house was situated on a perfect corner lot, exactly one block from the local high school. The junior high let out at 3:30, while the high school let out at 3:45. She decided to make good use of those 15 minutes. Every day, she rushed home and set up a table in front of her house where she'd display popular brands of candy, chips and cookies. She'd also dump two 12-packs of soda into an ice-cold cooler. As soon as the high school final bell sounded, a steady stream of hungry and thirsty students walked right by her table—and couldn't resist. She made a tidy profit selling snacks and soda at a 300 percent markup! That is brilliant. That is entrepreneurship at its best. Today, this young woman is a recent college graduate, on the lookout for jobs in a tough market. The good news: she's been training herself to have a competitive edge from an early age! When I talked to her about her E.T. days, this is what she said: "Selling pop and candy at my corner stand was the best and easiest money I ever made!"

If your child has an entrepreneurial streak, nurture it. Help her find ways to market her business with flyers, e-blasts or word of mouth. There's nothing more exciting to an 11-year-old than making frequent deposits of cash into her very own bank account. Just don't let her forget to earmark 10 percent of her earnings for her Secret 10.